

COLORADO FIELD ORNITHOLOGISTS - SIGHT RECORD FORM

NEW STATE RECORD _____ UNUSUAL RECORD X

Red 1/29/01 wpl

7-0 (A)

Species: Red Phalarope (*Phalaropus fulicaria*)**Date:** 3 October 2000**Number seen:** one**Sex:** unknown**Plumage:** Juvenal
molting into basic**Locality:** Jackson Lake State Park**Elevation:** about 4438'**Nearest town:** Goodrich**County:** Morgan**Time observed:** about 17:55-18:05 MDT**Duration of observation:** about 10 minutes in one continuous view**Description:**

Initially, I observed, about 500 meters away, a large, gray and white phalarope that flew seconds after I first found in the scope. I followed it while it was in flight coming towards me. It landed among 4 basic-plumaged Red-necked Phalaropes (*Phalaropus lobatus*) approximately 200 meters from me. During this observation, I was on top of the dam looking down which gave me an unobstructed view of the lake and birds.

Same general body shape as *P. lobatus*, except about 20% larger bodied, with a longer, thick set neck, and thicker bill. In direct side-by-side comparison, the *P. fulicaria* bill was entirely black and very obvious, about the same length but at least twice as thick as the *P. lobatus* bills which were barely noticeable from that distance. It also sat in the water with a very erect posture (straight necked), sitting a little more than a head higher than the *P. lobatus*. The bird was mostly in basic plumage, except for a good smear of rusty-coloration on the side and front of its neck that came down onto the sides of its upper chest. The rest of its body was black, gray, and white. The head was mostly white except for black eye patches, rectangular in shape, that surrounded the eye and extended a short distance along the side of the head. The dark gray/black crown extended down its nape and hind neck. Its back was mostly light/medium gray with some black mottling. The folded wing showed mostly the same color gray as the back, but also had a long black stripe (greater or median coverts possibly). Except for the rusty color, the rest of the underparts were entirely bright white. In flight, the wings showed a long, white stripe running along the mid-wing the entire length of the wing from body to outer primaries. The tail and rump were white with a large, black stripe running through the center.

Separation from similar species:

The only other species I can think of to confuse with is *P. lobatus*, with which it was swimming with 4 of them. This bird was considerably larger-bodied, had a thicker bill, and the rusty coloration eliminates basic-plumaged *P. lobatus*. I could not have asked for a better comparison than to watch both species swimming side by side.

Describe the bird's song and call, if given, including method of delivery (i.e. from perch, in flight, duration): I heard none.

What is your prior experience with this and similarly-appearing species? I have seen dozens of basic-plumaged adults while birding on west coast pelagics, but this is my first juvenile bird.

Light conditions: heavily overcast, with the sun low on the horizon but still visible, unobstructed by clouds at the time and above the mountains. The sun was to the left of me and the bird.

Optical equipment used: Leica scope (20-60x)

Distance, and how estimated: estimated closest distance at 200 meters

Other observers who saw the bird with you: none

Other observers who saw the bird independently: Larry Semo

If photographed, type of equipment and film: I did not photograph

List books, illustrations, recordings, other birders, etc. consulted and how this influenced your identification:

a) at time of observation: none

b) after observation: National Geographic Birds of North America, 3rd ed.

Reporting observer: Doug Faulkner

Signature: 

Address: Rocky Mountain Bird Observatory, 14500 Lark Bunting Lane, Brighton, CO 80601

Date report was written: This report was written on 3 October 2000 from memory about 3 hours after the sighting.